

100 Idioms + Meanings + Examples

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1. A Blessing In Disguise

- **Meaning:** Something that seems bad or unlucky at first but turns out to be good.
- **Example:** Losing that job was a **blessing in disguise** because it pushed me to start my own business.

2. A Dime A Dozen

- **Meaning:** Very common and easy to find.
- **Example:** Those souvenir keychains are a **dime a dozen** at the tourist shops.



3. All Ears

- **Meaning:** Fully listening and paying attention.
- **Example:** Go ahead, I'm **all ears**. Tell me what's been on your mind.

4. All In The Same Boat

- **Meaning:** In the same situation or predicament.
- **Example:** Everybody on staff got a pay cut – we're **all in the same boat**.

5. Barking Up The Wrong Tree

- **Meaning:** Looking in the wrong place, taking a wrong path/direction

- **Example:** If you think I took your book, you're **barking up the wrong tree**. I haven't seen it.

6. Beat Around The Bush

- **Meaning:** Avoiding the main topic or being indirect.
- **Example:** Stop **beating around the bush** and tell me why you didn't show up to my birthday party.

7. Bite The Bullet

- **Meaning:** To face a difficult or unpleasant situation bravely.
- **Example:** I have to **bite the bullet** and tell him the truth, even though it might hurt him.

8. Bury The Hatchet

- **Meaning:** To reconcile or make peace after a conflict.
- **Example:** After years of not speaking to each other, they finally decided to **bury the hatchet** and become friends again.



9. By The Skin Of Your Teeth

- **Meaning:** Just barely or narrowly escaping a difficult situation.
- **Example:** I passed the exam **by the skin of my teeth**; I got the minimum required score.

10. Call It A Day

- **Meaning:** To stop working or to end an activity.

- **Example:** We've been painting all afternoon; let's **call it a day** and continue tomorrow.

11. Cold Feet

- **Meaning:** Feeling nervous or hesitant about doing something.
- **Example:** I was going to ask her out, but I **got cold feet** at the last moment.



12. Cost An Arm And A Leg

- **Meaning:** To be very expensive.
- **Example:** That luxury car must have **cost him an arm and a leg**.

13. Cry Over Spilled Milk

- **Meaning:** To worry or complain about something that has already happened and cannot be changed.
- **Example:** Yes, we made a mistake, but there's no use **crying over spilled milk**. Let's focus on finding a solution.

14. Cut Corners

- **Meaning:** To do something quickly or take shortcuts, often sacrificing quality.
- **Example:** Don't **cut corners** on this project; it needs to be excellent to impress the new client.

15. Drive Someone Up The Wall

- **Meaning:** To irritate or annoy someone greatly.

- **Example:** Her constant humming **drives me up the wall**; I can't concentrate with that noise.

16. Silver Lining

- **Meaning:** something positive in a difficult situation.
- **Example:** Losing my job was tough, but the **silver lining** was that I found a new career opportunity.

17. Face The Music

- **Meaning:** To confront the consequences of one's actions.
- **Example:** You made a mistake, and now you have to **face the music** and accept the criticism.

18. Get A Taste Of Your Own Medicine

- **Meaning:** Experience the same negative treatment you have given to others.
- **Example:** After constantly making fun of others, he finally **got a taste of his own medicine** when they started teasing him.

19. Get The Ball Rolling

- **Meaning:** To start a process or activity.
- **Example:** Let's **get the ball rolling** on this project and assign tasks to the team members.



20. Give Someone The Benefit Of The Doubt

- **Meaning:** To believe someone's statement or excuse without being too suspicious.

- **Example:** I don't have any evidence, but I'll **give him the benefit of the doubt** and trust his explanation.

21. Go The Extra Mile

- **Meaning:** To put in extra effort or do more than what is expected.
- **Example:** If you want to succeed in this competitive industry, you need to **go the extra mile**.

22. Hit The Nail On The Head

- **Meaning:** To identify or describe something accurately.
- **Example:** She **hit the nail on the head** when she said that our team needs better communication.



23. In The Heat Of The Moment

- **Meaning:** In a moment of intense emotion, when we act or speak impulsively without thinking.
- **Example:** I didn't mean to say those hurtful words; I said them **in the heat of the moment**.

24. It's A Piece Of Cake

- **Meaning:** Something is very easy or simple to do.
- **Example:** Don't worry about the test; **it's a piece of cake**. You'll do fine.

25. Keep Your Chin Up

- **Meaning:** To remain positive and optimistic during difficult times.

- **Example:** Even though he faced many rejections, he **kept his chin up** and continued to pursue his dream.



26. Kill Two Birds With One Stone

- **Meaning:** Accomplish two things at the same time with a single action.
- **Example:** By taking the train instead of driving, she **kills two birds with one stone** – saves money and helps the environment.

27. Let The Cat Out Of The Bag

- **Meaning:** To reveal a secret or confidential information.
- **Example:** She accidentally **let the cat out of the bag** and spoiled the surprise party.

28. Like A Fish Out Of Water

- **Meaning:** Feeling uncomfortable or out of place in a particular situation.
- **Example:** As a city person, I **feel like a fish out of water** when I visit rural areas.

29. Make A Long Story Short

- **Meaning:** To give a brief summary or conclusion.
- **Example:** He rambled on about his trip, but to **make a long story short**, he had an amazing time.

30. Miss The Boat

- **Meaning:** To miss an opportunity or chance.
- **Example:** I didn't apply for the scholarship on time, so I **missed the boat**.

31. Not My Cup Of Tea

- **Meaning:** Something that is not to your liking or preference.
- **Example:** I tried skiing, but it's **not my cup of tea** – I don't enjoy the cold.



32. On Cloud Nine

- **Meaning:** Feeling extremely happy or joyful.
- **Example:** When she got the job offer, she was **on cloud nine**; it was her dream job.

33. Once In A Blue Moon

- **Meaning:** Happens very rarely.
- **Example:** We eat at home most of the time; we go to restaurants **once in a blue moon** – for special occasions.

34. Out Of The Blue

- **Meaning:** Unexpectedly or without any warning.
- **Example:** I hadn't spoken to her in years, and then **out of the blue**, she called me yesterday.

35. Over The Moon

- **Meaning:** Delighted or extremely happy.
- **Example:** She was **over the moon** when she received her acceptance letter from the university.



36. Pull Someone's Leg

- **Meaning:** To tease or joke with someone.
- **Example:** He's just **pulling your leg**; he doesn't really mean what he said.

37. Put The Cart Before The Horse

- **Meaning:** Doing things in the wrong order.
- **Example:** You're **putting the cart before the horse** by buying furniture before finding a place to live.

38. Raining Cats And Dogs

- **Meaning:** Raining heavily.
- **Example:** We can't go outside; it's **raining cats and dogs**.



39. Not Ring A Bell

- **Meaning:** Not sound familiar or trigger a vague memory.
- **Example:** I don't think I know him – his name **doesn't ring a bell**.

40. Rule Of Thumb

- **Meaning:** A general principle or guideline.
- **Example:** As a **rule of thumb**, it's better to arrive early for meetings.

41. Shoot Yourself In The Foot

- **Meaning:** To do something that harms oneself unintentionally.
- **Example:** He **shot himself in the foot** by quitting his job without having another one lined up.

42. On The Fence

- **Meaning:** To remain neutral or undecided in a dispute or issue.
- **Example:** I can't decide which car to buy, so I'm **on the fence** for now.



43. Skeletons In The Closet

- **Meaning:** Hidden or embarrassing secrets from the past.
- **Example:** The journalist investigated the famous singer, trying to find some **skeletons in the closet**.

44. Take A Rain Check

- **Meaning:** To postpone or reschedule a plan or invitation.
- **Example:** I'm sorry, I can't make it to the concert tonight. Can I **take a rain check**?

45. The Ball Is In Your Court

- **Meaning:** It's your turn to take action or make a decision.
- **Example:** I've given you all the information; now **the ball is in your court**.

46. The Best Of Both Worlds

- **Meaning:** Enjoying the benefits of two different things at the same time.
- **Example:** Working part-time allows me to have a career and spend time with my family. It's **the best of both worlds**.

47. Show Someone The Ropes

- **Meaning:** teach someone the details of a task or procedure

- **Example:** During my first week on the job, my co-workers **showed me the ropes**.

48. The Whole Nine Yards

- **Meaning:** Everything, or the full extent of something.
- **Example:** I'll make sure you have everything you need—equipment, resources, **the whole nine yards**.

49. Through Thick And Thin

- **Meaning:** Supporting or being loyal to someone during good times and bad times.
- **Example:** We've been friends for over 20 years, **through thick and thin**.

50. Throw In The Towel

- **Meaning:** To give up or surrender.
- **Example:** After struggling with the homework for hours, he finally **threw in the towel**.

51. Turn A Blind Eye

- **Meaning:** To ignore or pretend not to notice something.
- **Example:** The teacher **turned a blind eye** to the students whispering during the exam.

52. Under The Weather

- **Meaning:** Feeling sick.
- **Example:** I won't be able to come to work today; I'm feeling **under the weather**.



53. Off The Hook

- **Meaning:** Freed from an obligation
- **Example:** I was going to give a class on Saturday, but they found another teacher to do it, so I'm **off the hook**.

54. Up In The Air

- **Meaning:** Uncertain or not confirmed.
- **Example:** The date for the meeting is still **up in the air**; we need to schedule it.

55. When It Rains, It Pours

- **Meaning:** Bad things often happen in clusters or all at once.
- **Example:** First, my car broke down, then I lost my wallet. **When it rains, it pours!**

56. Wrap Your Head Around Something

- **Meaning:** To understand or comprehend something complex or difficult.
- **Example:** It took me a while to **wrap my head around** the new software, but now I understand how to use it.

57. Throw Someone For A Loop

- **Meaning:** Distract, confuse, or surprise someone suddenly.
- **Example:** I think I answered all the questions in the job interview pretty well – except for the random one about my personal life. I wasn't expecting it, so it **threw me for a loop**.

58. At The Drop Of A Hat

- **Meaning:** Immediately or without hesitation.
- **Example:** He's always ready to help **at the drop of a hat**.



59. At The End Of Your Rope

- **Meaning:** Completely annoyed, exhausted, or desperate, with no more patience or energy.
- **Example:** After dealing with two disobedient kids all day, I was **at the end of my rope**.

60. Pipe Down!

- **Meaning:** Be quiet!
- **Example:** Hey kids, **pipe down!** This is a library and people are trying to study.

61. Cross That Bridge When You Come To It

- **Meaning:** To deal with a problem or worry about something when it actually happens.
- **Example:** I'm not sure what to do if I fail the test, but I'll **cross that bridge when I come to it**.

62. Drop The Ball

- **Meaning:** To make a mistake or fail to do something properly.
- **Example:** He **dropped the ball** by forgetting to send the important email on time.

63. Elephant In The Room

- **Meaning:** An obvious problem or issue that no one wants to address.
- **Example:** We need to talk about the budget cuts; it's **the elephant in the room**.

64. Get Off On The Wrong Foot

- **Meaning:** To start a relationship or situation poorly or with a misunderstanding.
- **Example:** We **got off on the wrong foot**, but we can still work things out and improve our communication.

65. Go Down In Flames

- **Meaning:** To fail spectacularly or experience a significant defeat or failure.
- **Example:** Their new product launch **went down in flames**, and they lost a lot of money.



66. Go With The Flow

- **Meaning:** To adapt to a situation or accept things as they come.
- **Example:** I don't have a specific plan for the weekend; I'll just **go with the flow** and see what happens.

67. Hang In There

- **Meaning:** To persevere or keep going despite difficulties or challenges.
- **Example:** I know it's tough, but **hang in there**; things will get better.

68. In Hot Water

- **Meaning:** In trouble or facing difficulties due to a mistake or wrongdoing.
- **Example:** He found himself **in hot water** after missing an important deadline.

69. Jump On The Bandwagon

- **Meaning:** To join or support something that is currently popular or successful.
- **Example:** Everyone is using that new social media platform, so I decided to **jump on the bandwagon**.

70. Kick The Bucket

- **Meaning:** Die (very informal)
- **Example:** I'd love to visit Jamaica someday before I **kick the bucket**.



71. Swallow Something Hook, Line, And Sinker

- **Meaning:** To believe something completely – usually something that is not true.
- **Example:** When I got back late from the party, I told my mom I had been studying for a final exam at a friend's house. She **swallowed it hook, line, and sinker**.

72. Show Your True Colors

- **Meaning:** Reveal the true nature of your character
- **Example:** When things get stressful, that's when people start to **show their true colors**

73. On Thin Ice

- **Meaning:** In a dangerous situation.
- **Example:** He's **on thin ice** with his boss after making multiple mistakes.

74. Play It By Ear

- **Meaning:** To decide or act based on the situation as it develops, rather than having a fixed plan.
- **Example:** We don't have a specific itinerary; we'll just **play it by ear** and see what we feel like doing.

75. Save Your Breath

- **Meaning:** To stop wasting your time and effort saying things that won't have any effect.
- **Example:** Trying to convince him to change his mind is pointless; **save your breath**.

76. Steal The Show

- **Meaning:** To attract the most attention or praise.
- **Example:** Her performance was incredible; she **stole the show** with her singing and dancing.

77. Take It With A Grain Of Salt

- **Meaning:** To receive/consider information with skepticism or doubt.
- **Example:** I heard a rumor, but I **took it with a grain of salt** until I had more information.



78. Clear As Mud

- **Meaning:** information or communication is NOT clear at all.
- **Example:** My friend tried to explain how to get to his house, but his directions were as **clear as mud** and we got lost.

79. Jump The Gun

- **Meaning:** Do something too early, before the appropriate time
- **Example:** She **jumped the gun** and announced the winner before the final results were officially declared.

80. Get Your Wires Crossed

- **Meaning:** Have a miscommunication
- **Example:** We must have **gotten our wires crossed** – I wanted you to come at 7 PM, not 7 AM.



81. Throw Caution To The Wind

- **Meaning:** To take a risk or act without considering the potential consequences.
- **Example:** Despite her friends' warnings, she decided to **throw caution to the wind** and quit her job to pursue her passion.

82. Lose Your Touch

- **Meaning:** To lose the skill or ability that one once had.
- **Example:** After years of not playing the piano, he realized he had **lost his touch** and struggled to play a simple melody.

83. Off The Chain

- **Meaning:** Refers to something that is exciting, exceptional, or out of control.
- **Example:** The concert last night was **off the chain!** The energy in the crowd was unbelievable.

84. Eyeball It

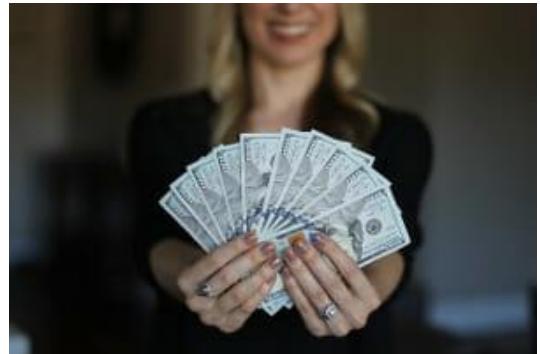
- **Meaning:** To estimate or measure something by using one's judgment or visual assessment.
- **Example:** We didn't have a ruler, so we had to **eyeball** the length of the table and hope it would fit in the room.

85. Spice Things Up

- **Meaning:** To add excitement or variety to a situation or relationship.
- **Example:** Let's try a new restaurant tonight to **spice things up**.

86. Bring Home The Bacon

- **Meaning:** To earn a living or provide financial support for one's family.
- **Example:** She works two jobs to **bring home the bacon** and support her children.



87. Nip Something In The Bud

- **Meaning:** To stop or prevent a problem or situation from developing further.
- **Example:** My 5-year-old started telling lies; we had to discipline her to **nip that habit in the bud**.

88. The Last Straw

- **Meaning:** The final event or action that makes a situation unbearable or prompts a strong reaction.
- **Example:** When he forgot their anniversary, it was **the last straw** for her, and she decided to end the relationship.

89. A Whole New Ballgame

- **Meaning:** A completely different situation or set of circumstances.
- **Example:** We had to change our lifestyle after we had kids – it **was a whole new ballgame**.

90. Burn The Midnight Oil

- **Meaning:** To work or study late into the night.
- **Example:** I'm exhausted because I was **burning the midnight oil** yesterday.



91. Between A Rock And A Hard Place

- **Meaning:** Trapped in a difficult or impossible situation, having to choose between two unfavorable options.
- **Example:** She was **between a rock and a hard place** when both job offers required her to relocate.

92. Play Devil's Advocate

- **Meaning:** Argue an opposing perspective in order to generate critical thinking or debate.
- **Example:** I know everyone's in favor of this plan, but let me **play devil's advocate** – what will we do if it all goes wrong?

93. Put Your Foot In Your Mouth

- **Meaning:** To say something embarrassing, inappropriate, or offensive by accident.
- **Example:** I **put my foot in my mouth** when I asked her if she was pregnant, but she wasn't.

94. Get A Grip

- **Meaning:** To regain control over one's emotions or behavior.
- **Example:** He needs to **get a grip** and stop letting his anger affect his relationships.

95. Piece Of Work

- **Meaning:** Used to describe someone who is difficult, eccentric, or challenging to deal with.
- **Example:** I love my cousin, but she's **a real piece of work** – she gets offended over the slightest things.

96. Put Someone On The Spot

- **Meaning:** To ask someone a difficult question or request an immediate response, often in a public or challenging situation.
- **Example:** During the meeting, the boss **put him on the spot** by asking him to present his idea without any preparation.



97. A Night Owl

- **Meaning:** Someone who likes to stay up late.

- **Example:** My son's a **night owl** – he never goes to bed before 2 AM.

98. Has Seen Better Days

- **Meaning:** Something is old and in not-so-great condition.
- **Example:** I've had this car for over fifteen years... **it's seen better days.**

99. Get Bent Out Of Shape

- **Meaning:** Become angry, upset or offended, especially about something which in your opinion doesn't justify such a reaction.
- **Example:** My roommate is a neat freak, and he **gets bent out of shape** if I leave a single spoon on the kitchen counter.

100. Play Your Cards Right

- **Meaning:** Use your resources in a way that leads to success.
- **Example:** Your supervisor really likes you. If you **play your cards right**, you could get promoted soon.

Learn 300 Idioms in 30 Days

Learn lots more idioms inside my [300 Idioms Course!](#)

This course is an EFFECTIVE way to learn and practice common idiomatic expressions in the English language. It's not just a list of idioms – instead, each lesson helps you learn the expressions more actively:

- The lessons start by showing you examples of idioms in sentences, and you'll try to guess what they mean from the context.
- Then, you can watch a video where I teach the idioms' meanings.
- Next, try a quiz to see how well you remember the idiomatic expressions.
- Finally, there are short-answer questions to help you practice using these common idioms yourself – and you can get feedback and correction from an Espresso English teacher!

